My Name on Her Lips

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36720259.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Summary

Adora is She-ra, Princess of Power, symbol of hope for the Rebellion. Adora... is also a Force Captain of the Horde. Not anymore, of course, she just was *once*. The Rebellion wouldn't trust her if they knew – for all she knows they would lock her up and throw away the key – but they need her to win the war. Adora's only choice is to hide her true identity, only ever known as She-ra to her friends.
If only her nemesis wasn't the only one who knows the truth.
(Secret identity Adora/She-ra AU, canon divergent)

Notes

If you haven't watched the original show, She-ra was supposed to be Adora's "secret identity" in it with only a select few knowing that she was She-ra. This AU was inspired by trying to make that work in the reboot, diverging from canon once they arrive in Bright Moon in Episode 3 but largely following the show's plot beats, just with Adora as She-ra the whole time when they are on missions.
Oh, and also Adora and Catra totally boned in the Horde. :<

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was Glimmer's idea to lie to her mom about who Adora was. Apparently she wouldn't accept a Horde soldier under her roof, but she would love She-ra. The problem was Adora couldn't summon She-ra. She nearly got caught trying to sneak around, but running into Razz opened her eyes. Something clicked inside her and she isn't worried about summoning She-ra now – she is just a *little* anxious about her ability to keep her up all the time.

"How have you come here now, after so long?" Angella asks her, surrounded by an entire throne room of people that Adora can't help but feel are scrutinizing her every move. It feels like someone might declare that they recognize her at any moment despite the skirt, hair, and tiara. She doesn't think she looks much like herself anymore and no one outside of the Fright Zone should recognize Adora as a member of the Horde *anyway*, but it is a nerve-wracking experience.

Glimmer shoots Adora a panicked, wide-eyed look that clearly says *keep your shit together*, but Adora didn't realize there was so much history to She-ra. Well, the mural was a tipoff, but she didn't know that others would know about her and expect Adora to be the same person from legends. She can't pretend to be some ancient being who has resurfaced. She doesn't have the knowledge to make that believable for even a few minutes.

"I'm not the She-ra from legends. I think She-ra resides in this sword. It called out to me and lets me channel her power," Adora admits, watching Glimmer immediately put a hand on her head. It isn't a full facepalm, but it is such a painfully familiar look on someone else that Adora flashes back to Etheria and the horrified look on Catra's face for a moment before she is rudely pulled back to the current time by

Angella sweeping forward and looking down at her with a calculating eye.

"She's a good person, Mom. Bow and I met her before she transformed," Glimmer hurries to assure her, rushing forward to send an innocent smile up at the queen that Adora doubts anybody has ever fallen for. Predictably, Angella raises an eyebrow at her daughter.

"She found the sword in the Whispering Woods. We went into them looking for it too after we picked up its signal on my tracker pad. You know that they don't let bad people through," Bow adds on, stepping forward to back Glimmer up. To Adora's surprise, Angella almost seems more willing to listen with Bow's endorsement, hesitating before she looks back to Adora and scrutinizes her.

"And what do you have to say for yourself?" she asks. Adora draws in a breath. Now would be the moment to admit it if she is ever going to, but she may very well find herself thrown in a dungeon. She wants to *help* and she can't do it locked up. She has to go along with Glimmer's plan. If she didn't think Angella would accept a Horde soldier, who would know better than the queen's daughter?

"I've seen firsthand the atrocities that the Horde can commit. I want to fight them and protect the people of Etheria, but I have to keep my real identity a secret. My...There is someone at the Horde's mercy that they would be hurt if they learned that I was with the Rebellion," Adora lies. It isn't the smoothest lie that she has ever told, especially when she stumbles over what to call Catra, but it is in the upper ranks honestly.

She has some experience with having to come up with a quick cover when she and Catra would get caught breaking rules or a prank took an unexpected turn, but she has never been good at it. Angella pauses, and for a second Adora is afraid that she is going to call her out on her bullshit, but after a long moment Angella's expression seems to soften a bit, remorse tinging her gaze as she gently shakes her head.

"The Horde has put many of our loved ones at risk. I lost my husband in the fight against them," Angella says. Adora suddenly feels like she has been seen through in an odd way. She doesn't think Angella suspects who she is – her gaze is far too soft for that – but she has a feeling Angella might be able to tell who Adora's *someone* is, at least in relation to herself. Adora swallows, nodding in understanding, though the motion feels awkward. She is unused to the weight of She-ra's hair. Angella looks at her for another long moment.

"We will accept your pledge, but if you or your situation ever puts the Rebellion or any citizen of Bright Moon at risk, we will not hesitate to act," Angella says, her voice so smooth and authoritative that it takes Adora a second to realize she has been threatened. Still, she quickly nods and Glimmer bursts out in a happy cheer. The next thing that Adora knows, Glimmer has run into her side and wrapped her in a hug, Bow following the moment after. Neither of them go that high up on She-ra, but Adora gladly hugs them back.

She takes a moment to enjoy the embrace before she has to face the reality of the situation that she has walked into.

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Adora ends up with a room down the hall from Glimmer's. She borrows some old pajamas of Glimmer's that don't quite fit her and mournfully watches Glimmer take a letter opener to her old top until the Horde logo on the back is unrecognizable. Then Glimmer sets it on fire for good measure, which very nearly ends in disaster and calls her mother's attention, but Glimmer manages to convince her that she was just getting overly dramatic about burning a diary page while Adora and Bow crouch behind a loveseat and pray Angella doesn't realize they are hiding in the room.

Glimmer gives her a small golden pin to hold her belt closed instead of her old badge. When Adora next looks in the mirror, she doesn't look like herself. She still has her jacket, but she isn't used to its golden edition, and her shirt is purple, loose, and unfamiliar. At least she got to keep her pants since they were nondescript enough. Glimmer and Bow explain measurements and tailors to her, doing their best to take Adora's down for her and promising her that she will soon have clothes that will be as close to what she is comfortable as can be gotten away with.

Officially, Adora is a nobody refugee from Thaymor. Angella pulls them aside after the public meeting in the throne room saying that she will allow Adora to do what is necessary to protect her loved ones, but that she, as the queen, needs to know who she really is. Adora doesn't know how well she passed herself off as a nobody, but she knows that realistically Angella isn't be able to look at her real face and tell that she was part of Horde. She never even saw active duty before she defected, so it isn't like anyone outside of their ranks can recognize her.

Technically, She-ra's identity will be kept secret, as will Adora's. When She-ra is needed for something, Adora will transform into her while out of sight. Adora herself will just become a part of the castle household with no role in the Rebellion. Adora has no reason to attend Rebellion meetings, so people who are actually part of the effort to fight the Horde will only ever meet She-ra. They will be just two of the many people who come to Bright Moon castle for a variety of reasons.

"A pleasure to meet you," Angella says coolly, regarding Adora somewhat skeptically as she shakes her hand. Maybe she expected She-ra to be older beneath the glow, but Adora doesn't know why she would look older as She-ra, so she doesn't think she has done anything to mislead her on that front. Adora gives an awkward half-bow while still holding her hand.

"You too, your majesty," Adora returns. It is a precarious situation, but Adora needs to right the wrongs that the Horde has committed,

and if the Rebellion will help her do that, then she will be who she needs to be to work for them.

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"You sounded like you were being sincere when you told Angella that the Horde has someone close to you," Bow prods gently late one night. There is no way to poke at the subject of Catra without opening up a festering wound, though. Adora immediately buries her face down into the pillow she is propping her elbows up on. All three of them are lying on the floor of her room, chatting before bed. Glimmer and Bow are sleeping over so Adora can sleep and Adora was sprawled out on her stomach before Bow asked the question.

"Catra. The girl from Thaymor," she mumbles into the pillow. She can practically hear Bow and Glimmer exchanging a look above her head. A moment later, one of Bow's gentle-but-calloused hands lands on her shoulder and rubs as if that can soothe the hurt in Adora's chest. She was pulling a reason out of her ass, but it turned out to be the truth. That's probably the only reason it was believable.

"She was a cadet with me. If our superior officer finds out that I'm She-ra... I worry she might retaliate," Adora explains. She hates admitting that she could be the reason that Catra gets hurt. There is no good scenario for Adora here. Adora knows the right thing to do is fight the Horde and that Catra can take care of herself, but she still worries about her being on her own. As soon as Adora saw her in Thaymor she thought that she could bring Catra with her and then they would be safe and together, but Catra turned away from her.

Adora still doesn't know why, she just knows that the image of her disappearing in the dust and smoke hurts her more than any other memory. Bow's hand on her shoulder is a poor replacement for Catra curled up at the foot of her bed or putting her in a teasing headlock.

Glimmer shuffles a bit closer and then Adora feels a second hand on her other shoulder, squeezing gently. Yeah, not assuring enough.

"You were friends?" Glimmer asks. Adora barks a muffled laugh into the pillow beneath her before she can stop herself.

Yeah, something like that.

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There's a wrench in their plan that none of them really considered – namely, Catra. Even if she hadn't seen Adora drop the transformation back at Thaymor, she would recognize Adora in any form that she took. At the Sea Gate, Catra says her name and Adora panics. Luckily, everyone else is a little distracted trying to stop the Horde ship from taking down the Sea Gate, but no one has ever known Adora like Catra does, and she notices.

"Wait- Do they not *know*? Do they think that you're a good little princess like the rest of them?" Catra asks her. Adora's heart is in her stomach. The beam coming from the sword flickers, her concentration split. The wounds Catra dug into She-ra don't register anymore in comparison to the panic now consuming her. Catra outright laughs, mirth in her tones.

"Oh, that's rich. What would the Rebellion say if they knew, do you think?" Catra asks, her tone dark. The next moment, Adora feels Catra's breath hot in her ear. "Would you have to come running back to me after they try to throw you in a cell? Your little crusade just got even *harder*," Catra sneers in her ear. The beam flickers again, but before Catra can say something that cuts her even deeper, a jet of water arcs over the platform and hits Catra, knocking her off of her perch on Adora's back and sending her down into the water below.

The pain of Catra's claws wrenching out from where they were dug in to hold her up is outweighed by the relief of knowing that she can't keep digging into Adora's most vulnerable parts. Adora glances down towards the water, catching sight of Catra resurfacing. She breathes a bit easier. Her eyes find Mermista in the waves and she sends her a grateful smile. Mermista waves back an acknowledgement. Adora can finally turn back to the Sea Gate and refocus on fixing it.

Even with Catra beneath the platform, though, concern roils in Adora's gut. How long can they get away with this?

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Mystacor very nearly threatens to blow the lid on the whole thing – Castaspella definitely seemed suspicious about Adora's claims to have slept through the whole thing and She-ra miraculously showing up just when she was needed – but the sorceress is Glimmer's family, so hopefully she can keep the secret. Adora doesn't exactly feel rested when they return to Bright Moon, but her entire life is stress. Knowing that Shadow Weaver has figured out that she is She-ra ups the pressure.

The only shining light right now is that Catra definitely hasn't told Shadow Weaver that it is a secret amongst the Rebellion. The first thing that Shadow Weaver would have done is try to expose the fact that She-ra was once a Force Captain. Adora finds herself compulsively checking the sword's hiding place whenever she returns to her bedroom. She knows that no one should be touching it, but it feels like her entire life is hanging by a thread.

Adora is living in a state of constant paranoia. Nightmares plague her, and even worse, sometimes dreams of Catra do. She wakes up with the ghost of Catra in her bed. When she opens her eyes it

shatters the illusion of her best friend in her arms. She feels like she is losing her mind. She wants to go back into battle. Punching her way from a tank might be just want she needs to clear her head, but instead princess prom comes around with a diplomatic mission.

She-ra gets an invitation, but she cant attend on account of the whole *no weapons* rule. If Adora wants to maintain her cover, she has to attend as a normal civilian in the form of Glimmer's plus-one. She would prefer to be hitting things, but maybe recruiting Princess Frosta and making progress for the Rebellion will make her feel better. At least, if they can manage it.

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Catra shows up and a part of Adora's brain breaks. She forgets that she isnt supposed to know her. She manages to scramble and come up with the excuse that she knows Catra is with the Horde because Glimmer has fought her – *her because head* , Adora says, the words tasting bitter and hypocritical on her tongue – when Mermista asks her why she cares so much, but she doesnt think even that excuses it when she follows Catra into a quiet hallway off from the main ball.

"You know, I was sure there had to be something else going on, but now I see you really are stupid enough to think you can keep who you are a secret," Catra drawls the moment that they are alone, grinning smugly when Adora fists her hands at her side. Catra seems to enjoy anything she says that upsets Adora. Catra has always been a bit of a shit, but it was never like *this* before. Now she revels in the reactions that she draws out of Adora, good or bad, but mostly bad.

"This is the worst idea that you've ever had," Catra adds before she launches forward. For a second, Adora thinks that she is attacking

her despite the truce, but instead Catra pins her against the frozen wall and grins at her. The position is painfully familiar, as is the predatory grin on Catra's face. Adora knows that they *can't* be doing this here – *now* – but her mind just spins in circles trying to come up with any other explanation for the situation.

"It wasn't my idea," is the only thing that she manages to come up with, painfully aware of Catra's body pressing up against her in this infuriatingly attractive suit. Adora's mind went blank when Catra walked into the ball for a *number* of reasons and she is never going to get the image of this suit out of her mind. Catra seems to enjoy Adora's speechlessness, leaning in and smirking at her. She's so *close*.

"There's still no hope for you if you agreed to it. Let me guess, Twinkle? Crop Top seems to have at least a quarter of sense in his head," Catra drawls. Adora knows that she should defend her friends, but she is afraid of what is going to happen if she opens her mouth, so instead she just nods. Catra chuckles, the sound dark and bitter.

"I'm only going along with this because I want to see how long it takes for you to fuck it up yourself. I can't believe that you've made it this far, but I guess it just proves that the Rebellion are idiots," Catra tells her. Adora gets a half second of relief and then Catra is dropping to her knees. Adora gapes down at her as Catra sends her a wink and lifts the edge of her skirt, disappearing beneath it. A second later, a harsh nip sinks into the flesh of her thigh and Adora's hand goes flying up to her mouth to stifle a loud gasp.

"*You can't be serious*," Adora hisses as Catra grabs her thighs and spreads them. From beneath her skirt, Catra's tail swishes over the ground with amusement, the only part of her that Adora can see with her skirt tenting out over Catra's mane. Catra's reply is another nip, this time high up on her inner thigh, as she hooks her fingers into Adora's underwear.

"It's a party, princess. I'm just celebrating," Catra replies. This is far from the first time that they have been in this position, but given the last few months, Adora was certain the last time was their *last*. "I want you to go back to that party reeking of sex. Now be quiet," Catra orders her. Adora bites down on her own hand as Catra pulls her underwear down and licks a long stripe against her.

That motivation almost makes sense to her. Catra is trying to ruin her in front of everybody, but Adora isn't about to let her. Well, she is definitely going to let Catra do *this*, she can't say no to her and it has been so long, but she will walk back into the party the picture of composure. She hasn't seen many hybrids around to sniff them out. As long as Adora manages to act normal, no one has to know just how *familiar* she and Catra are with each other.

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Catra won't kiss her, but she lets Adora flip them after she straightens up and wipes off her mouth. Adora was so distracted by Catra that she doesn't realize how cold the wall was until her back is exposed to the open air again—it now feels shockingly *hot* on her skin despite how cold she knows it actually is—but she doesn't give herself a moment to adjust, her hands wandering beneath Catra's suit jacket to squeeze along her body. Catra tilts her head back against the wall and sends Adora a smug, almost dismissive look that makes her blood boil as if she didn't *just* get off.

"You're infuriating," Adora informs her as she drops a hand to her waistband and begins fumbling with her fly. If Catra wants to ruin her, two can play at that game. She has been making Adora look like a fool all evening and Adora is eager to make her own move in this game instead of being led around, two steps behind and desperately scrambling after Catra. For all that justification, she can't deny that

some of her dreams about Catra have been related to *this* and she just wants to touch her again.

"And yet you can't get enough of me," Catra returns smugly. She arches her hips into Adora's touch when she gets her hand in her clothes and starts touching her, but she is, well, *infuriatingly* well composed still. Adora releases a low groan not dissimilar to a growl as she ducks her head forward. Catra quickly turns her face away, dodging a kiss, but Adora knew that she was going to do that again and she wasn't actually going in for a kiss. Instead she buries her face in Catra's neck and bites her, well aware that Catra likes it.

She is pretty sure that Catra likes it for biological reasons while Adora loves when Catra does the same to her because the points of her fangs feel like ecstasy, but either way she earns a quick gasp, Catra's chest jumping beneath her. Adora soaks it in, proud to have elicited any kind of reaction from Catra when she is trying to be in such careful control. Adora misses when their touches could be slow and almost reverent, but there was usually still an edge of desperation to their encounters. It is taken to the extreme now that they stand on opposite sides of the war, but Adora will take any way that she gets to have Catra.

She wants Catra's moans to be rattling off the wall and her hair to grow mussed from her losing herself and thrashing her head back and forth in her pleasure, but Adora has to settle for muted sighs and smug, almost degrading comments that only make her own desire climb higher. Adora's favorite thing about when they touch each other was always afterwards when she got to hold a purring and content Catra, but after Catra's breath hitches, her hips rutting forward and then her entire body relaxing back against the wall, she hardly hesitates to push Adora away, doing up her fly herself as Adora sends her a pleading look.

"Please, Catra. It doesn't have to be like this," Adora says, well aware that Catra is about to walk away and that she can't even chase after her right away without giving them away. She doesn't know why things have to be so antagonistic between them. They're

best friends. She just wants Catra back on her side again. Catra, for her part, scoffs as she adjusts her suit and sends Adora a look of disdain.

"You're the one who left," she shoots back, her voice bitter. She darts away before Adora can even open her mouth. Adora is left standing in an empty hallway feeling hollow inside. The ice isn't just on the walls, freezing her veins as she looks down at the ground where Catra stood just a moment ago. Absently, Adora raises her hand that was on Catra to her face and breathes deeply. She can smell the traces of her on her fingers, the only proof left that Catra let down her guard for even a moment.

Adora has never left feeling so empty from one of her private encounters with Catra. Even feeling like this, she would redo the whole thing again in a heartbeat. She can't say no to Catra. She can't even look away from her. She forces herself to move, finding a powder room to clean herself up in and wash her hands. When she walks back into the ball, she acts like nothing happened. It only seems to drive Catra higher up the wall, but at the end of the night, Catra is the one who wins the battle.

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Adora comes back late from a long day of training with Light Hope and barely has the presence of mind to stow the sword away before she goes to raid the kitchen for an easy dinner. When she returns to her room, she does her usual compulsive check on the sword that has only grown worse since the battle of Bright Moon and finds her worst nightmare has happened: the sword is *gone*.

Adora stares down at the empty case that she keeps stowed away in the wardrobe. She has been hiding the sword inside it ever since Mystacor. She was grateful for its hiding spot when Glimmer and

Bow were taken because it meant that the sword at least was safe and she could use it to lead the rescue mission as She-ra, but afterwards she felt bitter, wondering if she would have been able to keep Glimmer and Bow from being abducted in the first place if she brought it to the prom. Then they wouldnt have had to mount a rescue and they never would have lost Entrapta.

This stupid secret identity plan might have kicked of f a chain of events that ended in a memorial service. They know Entrapta is alive and with the Horde now , but it is a kick in the gut to see the sword missing after all that inner turmoil. Someone found it, and worse, *took* it. Did Adora leave it behind only for it to be discovered later, making all the pain and suffering between unnecessary? Her blood feels frozen in her body , along with her thoughts, as she tries to process the empty case in her lap.

"I would have thought this thing was better guarded," drawls a familiar voice behind her. Adora scrambles to her feet, whipping around and gaping at Catra. She is lounging on the railing of Adora's balcony like it is a chaise lounge and not a ledge so narrow that Adora worries about setting her drinks on it. She *definitely* wasnt there when Adora walked in, but there is an overhang above the balcony doors that prevents rain from getting in and she could have been hiding up there to make a dramatic entrance.

Adora is rooted to the spot, staring at Catra lounging in the glowing moonlight of Bright Moon as she casually holds the Sword of Protection as if it is an easily replaceable standard-issue Horde staf f. Adora doesnt know how Catra even got here. Not that Bright Moon is that fortified, but navigating her way here cant have been easy . The fact that the Whispering W oods are still crawling with members of the Rebellion trying to defend them after the freeze retreated doesnt help.

Catra hops off the railing like her presence in Bright Moon is nothing. She strolls into Adora's room with as much familiarity as she walks the halls of the Fright Zone. Her gaze travels around it for a moment. She must have looked around earlier to find the sword, so she is

probably only looking now so that Adora can see the disdain in her gaze. Adora doesn't know what to say. The last time that they saw each other in person was a knockdown, drag-out fight. She felt Catra's ribs crunch at one point. The time before that wasn't much better.

Adora doesn't know what she is playing at with the sword, either. She could have easily run off with it or hid it. Adora doesn't know what this strategy could possibly be, but Catra comes to a halt just out of arms' reach. Adora knows Catra after training with her for a lifetime. She has given herself just enough room to leap back out of reach if Adora makes a lunge for the sword and they both know it. She is taunting her.

"People don't go rifling through each other's things in Bright Moon. Usually it's safe in here," Adora informs her, eyeing Catra up. Her motivations remain inscrutable to her. Catra's head tilts ever so slightly to the side, the tips of her ears bouncing with the movement. Even with the last few months stretching between them, the part of Adora that always perks up when Catra does something cute immediately squeals. Adora shoves the reaction down with the weight of her anxiety and guilt.

"Weird," Catra scoffs. Privacy isn't really a thing in the Horde, but they do all have their lockers. Even those are fair game if you leave it unlocked, though. People love to be nosy and there is a constant game of stealing the best equipment from whoever managed to get their hands on it last. Adora takes a hopeful step forward and Catra predictably steps back. Only she could make such a quick movement look so casual.

"Not a chance," Catra tells her, raising a brow at her. Adora pouts at her, but Catra startles her by suddenly leaping up to the side, vaulting off the wall as if it is merely a stepping stone for her to reach the chandelier. Adora gapes up at it as Catra casually tosses the sword onto it midair. By the time that Catra has landed back on the ground, the sword is wedged amongst the chandelier arms, far

outside for Adora's reach even with a ladder. Her only hope of getting it back is asking for Glimmer 's help teleporting up there.

Okay, so Catra definitely isn't trying to steal it, but-

"What the fuck?" Adora asks a bit indignantly , turning back to Catra. Catra's grin is wide and satisfied. She seems to be reveling in having taken Adora's weapon from her. Adora has no idea what she is doing —here or with the sword —but explaining how the sword got up there is going to be *hard* . Adora isn't exactly eager to admit that Catra was here and she didn't immediately yell for guards or something, but who knows, Catra might not exit quietly and Adora's hand will be forced.

"I don't want to deal with your magic bullshit," Catra informs her , reaching out and fisting her hand in Adora's jacket. Adora's brain short-circuits as Catra hauls her forward into a kiss. She knows that she should push Catra away, but Catra is actually *kissing* her this time. Adora finds her hands on Catra's hips even as Catra walks them backwards to the bed. An entire war and its casualties are between them but Adora still falls into Catra's arms like it is nothing.

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Adora actually gets to hold Catra afterwards this time. Catra puts her to work, her hands demanding as she directs Adora to take care of her. Adora does it eagerly despite the guilt weighing on her knowing that every day they are —indirectly or directly —battling each other for control of the Whispering Woods. None of that matters when Catra is in her bed. There is a delusional part of Adora that thinks if she just does this *right* then Catra will give up and stay.

Clearly they still have something. A twisted shadow of what it used to be, warped and mocking Adora with dreams of Catra in her arms

and her quiet sighs now ringing off the walls of her bedroom, but still there. Catra isn't as quiet as she was back in the Ice Palace, seeming more focused on just enjoying herself, though she is far from the purry and cuddly bed partner Adora is used to from before. Still, it feels better than the rendezvous in the hallway did.

Adora's heart is bolstered by the fact that Catra came all this way for her. For sex mostly, probably, but sex with *her*. She saw Catra hanging off Princess Scorpia's arm at the ball. The girl had muscle and looked at Catra like she was interested – then again, Adora doesn't know how anyone *wouldn't* be when Catra was in that suit – but Catra didn't do the safe or easy or *same* thing and turn to someone on her side of the war when she wanted to get off.

Then again, Catra is probably aware that she is in no danger from Adora like this. Someone else discovering them would be catastrophic whether it was a member of the Rebellion or the Horde, but Adora is just as motivated to keep these meetings secret as Catra is. After Catra comes, Adora basically flops on top of her, pinning her to the bed and burying her face in Catra's soft neck. She doesn't want Catra to go. She doesn't want to stop holding her and she definitely doesn't want her to return to the Fright Zone.

Catra belongs with her. Adora belongs *to* her. It's unnatural for them to be separated like this. That's why it is so easy to fall back into her embrace the moment that she shows up. Adora doesn't want to be anywhere but in her arms, burying her face in her fur until it is a bit difficult to breathe and luxuriating in her purr. Catra shifts slightly beneath her and Adora hurries to grab onto the sheets as if that will help her pin Catra down. Above her, Catra gives a small scoff. Adora isn't sure if she is imagining the amusement in it.

"I knew you would get clingy. It's just a hookup, princess," Catra tells her, but she doesn't shove Adora off her. Adora doesn't quite believe that – there is no *just* with them – but she isn't lying to herself about what this is. She wants Catra to walk away from the Horde and not look back, but she isn't expecting her to just because she came to

Adora for a bit of fun. Adora has to believe that she will reach Catra somehow, but she doubts that she is going to do it through sex.

"You're going to leave me hanging?" Adora tries, because appealing to Catra's competitive side is probably her best chance of cajoling her into staying longer. Catra's tail twitches and she huffs, but she is still purring. Then again, she tends to do that reflexively for a while after getting off. It's a miracle that she managed to push it down so quickly at princess prom, but in retrospect, Adora is pretty that Catra pulled her aside just to distract her while she put her plan into motion. What she did to keep her distracted, however, was her choice.

"You just want to keep cuddling," Catra accuses. Adora catches herself smiling into Catra's fur. It is things like this that give her hope. Of *course* she just wants to keep holding Catra, but even though Catra knows that, she hasn't made a move to leave again. At least not yet.

"Semantics," Adora replies, dropping a cautious kiss against Catra's collarbone. She hasn't kissed Adora again since the one that she lured Adora into bed with and Adora is worried that Catra would get up if she tried to kiss her properly now. The one to her shoulder doesn't seem to be too much of an offence, though.

"You're using that word wrong," Catra informs her, still not getting up. It feels weird to have Catra showing a bit of her softer side to her again. She is pretty sure that it won't last long, so Adora is going to enjoy it while it is lasts. She shifts up to kiss along the side of Catra's neck. Catra tilts her head to the side, giving Adora better access.

"You're the brains of the operation," Adora returns, as if they are still a unit and don't regularly meet each other on opposite sides of the battlefield. Adora knows that she should be angry with Catra, and sometimes she is, but at this moment she is a little focused kissing along her jaw. Catra snorts, but Adora know that she isn't about to protest that.

“How is your brilliant plan going, by the way?” Catra asks, sounding amused. As Adora shifts back down the length of Catra’s neck, afraid to try to kiss her mouth and be turned away, her heart flutters a little. It almost feels like one of their old whispered gossip sessions during their sleepovers back in the bunkroom.

“Glimmer and Bow knew all along. Queen Angella half knows. Glimmer’s aunt – that’s her dad’s sister – definitely suspects something, but I think I’m good aside from that,” Adora tells her. She doesn’t mention Entrapta. She was the only person to actually catch Adora dropping the transformation when she got infected back in the castle, but her anti-socialness worked to their advantage. She didn’t have anyone to tell. If Catra wants to know what Entrapta does, she can ask her for herself. According to Glimmer and Bow, she is with the Horde of her own free will.

Adora squeezes her arms tighter around Catra. Things like this should steel Adora, but instead they weaken her, leaving her clutching to Catra for comfort as she tries to assure herself that Entrapta made her choices and there was nothing that they could do. It isn’t like Adora managed to convince Catra to join the Rebellion and they were best friends at the time. Maybe it isn’t surprising that they lost Entrapta to the Horde too, even if Adora can’t understand how someone could justify working with them.

Catra seems unsure beneath her, clearly picking up on the change in Adora and unsure what brought it on. After a moment, a cautious hand lifts and places lightly on her back. Catra’s hand isn’t far from where her claws have raked down She-ra’s back before, but She-ra isn’t here right now and Adora doesn’t scar from her wounds. She hugs Catra tightly, grateful for her lingering. She knows it won’t last, but she will take every second until Catra bolts that she can get.

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“Will you come back?” Adora asks as Catra pulls her clothes back on. She let Adora hold her for a good ten minutes as silence hung between them. Adora closed her eyes and pretended they were back in the Horde, both of them blissfully unaware of the reality of the war that they were being raised to fight in. Adora can never help the Horde again, but sometimes a traitorous part of her wishes that she just didn’t know and could return to how life used to be. She knows that Catra was the only part of it that was good, but sometimes going back in time feels more realistic than Catra giving up her pride and joining the Rebellion.

“You wish,” Catra scoffs, which is Catra for *yes*. Adora lets out a slow breath, soothing herself with that thought. It probably won’t be any time soon—after all, it took Catra a long time to get to the point where she sought her out like this—but Adora will at least get to hold her again, even if it doesn’t end up being in her bed. It might be during another ill-advised rendezvous in a hallway, but Catra missed her and came to her. That has to mean something.

“Will you stay?” Adora asks next. She knows it is such a ridiculous request that Catra is likely to laugh at her, but it would be a moment of levity that might ease the ache already forming in her chest as Catra walks out onto the balcony. Catra doesn’t laugh. She stops walking, her hands fisting at her sides and shoulders *trembling* a little from how hard she is clenching her muscles. Adora’s heart pounds in her chest as Catra’s hands go slack and she blows out a breath that Adora barely hears back inside the room.

When Catra glances over her shoulder and sends Adora a look of disdain, she is the picture of control again.

“Fuck off,” she says, and then she vaults over the railing before Adora can stop her. She isn’t actually worried, but she still rushes forward and looks over the edge to find Catra scaling down the side of the building. Well, that explains how she got in unnoticed. Adora watches her descend back to the ground, her heart falling along with Catra’s elevation. That didn’t go over how she thought it would. There has been a gap between them ever since Thaymor.

Ever since she made the decision to turn away from the hand that Adora reached out to her, it feels like Catra's actions have been clouded in mystery. Adora used to know her so well. Now she sleeps alone, missing the only person who she wants with her. She turns back to her room, looking up to the chandelier with the sword still shoved through it. Explaining this one to Glimmer is going to be interesting. Maybe trying to come up with an excuse can distract her from the way that she is now yearning for Catra even worse than the usual constant ache of missing her.

Chapter End Notes

For any missions not mentioned, just assume that they went as they did in the show but Adora never dropped She-ra lol. This isn't a super detailed or long AU, it's just about the Yearning. I don't care about plot holes XD

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> CW for: suicidal thoughts/tendencies/idealation on Adora's part (the kind of stuff that is seen in the show at different points, though it is spelled out more clearly here).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There have been cracks before, but the Northern Reach is the first disastrous incident. Adora doesn't know how much the average cadet knows about her or She-ra, and she certainly doesn't know what Scorpia knows about the situation, but apparently Adora spends her entire day de-transformed with her. Entrapta is there too, but she already knew. Adora asked her to keep it secret after the Crypto Castle incident and Entrapta seemed delighted to, proud to have been entrusted with something.

"This is what friends do!" she declared excitedly. That memory haunted Adora in the gap of time between leaving Entrapta in the Fright Zone and discovering that she was working for the Horde. Despite the loyalty change, Adora wasn't worried about her spreading the secret around. Her reaction had been odd but *genuine*. Scorpia could be a problem – who knows what Adora said to her while she was out of it from the First Ones infection – but the bigger issue is *Sea Hawk*.

He has a big mouth. Adora is still recovering as he steers them back to warmer waters, slumped on the deck with her head between her knees. She will be fine in an hour or two, but right now she feels unsteady and adding in the boat has made her a bit nauseous. Above her, Bow and Glimmer are trying to impress the importance of keeping She-ra's identity a secret on Sea Hawk, but he seems bewildered by their argument.

"I'm sorry, why is it a secret?" Sea Hawk asks despite how they just explained that. Glimmer sighs aggressively, launching into an explanation of how much the Horde has taken from people and how they wouldn't accept Adora if they knew that she had a history with them. Apparently Scorpia told Sea Hawk that Catra and Adora were exes – or at least implied it – in addition to him discovering that Adora was She-ra. Exes implies a lot more *bone* between them than there really is, but correcting him on that would only make things worse. They might as well tell him that Adora was once a Force Captain too.

"I have some questionable past associates myself. I don't know why I would go around telling people about Adora's past," Sea Hawk says. Adora gives him a grateful thumbs up from the ground, but judging by their sighs, Glimmer and Bow aren't that assured.

"We need you to not tell people that Adora is She-ra for *any* reason," Glimmer reminds him. Telling people that one of Glimmer's best friends in the castle once dated a Horde soldier would be bad, but they also need him to keep her identity a secret. There is a long pause from Sea Hawk.

"I'm sorry, was that ever a secret?" he asks, sounding genuinely confused. The silence that follows is deafening. Adora lifts her head to find Glimmer blinking owlishly at Sea Hawk. Bow has his face in his hands.

"You already knew?" Adora asks. Sea Hawk looks back at her with pure confusion.

"Doesn't everyone?" he asks. Adora is pretty sure that something is breaking in Glimmer's brain – they have done a *lot* of work to hide this over the months and her facial expression kind of looks like she is going through all five stages of grief at once – but she manages to lift her hands and stretch up to place them on both of Sea Hawk's shoulders. Sea Hawk actually bends down a little to accommodate her even as she makes burningly intense eye contact with him.

“*Wait, keeping the*,” Glimmer tells him. Sea Hawk blinks at her with wide eyes before cautiously raising his hand and giving her a thumbs up.

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Adora isn't that surprised when Catra reappears at her window not long after they return from the Northern Reach. She doesn't remember things from when she was floppy, but it seemed like something that would spark a return. Adora is already in bed for the night when she hears a slight scrape on her balcony and holds her breath. A moment later, soft footpads approach the vanity and there is the gentle sound of something being put down.

Catra has once again used the cover of darkness to slip to Bright Moon, though Adora doesn't know how she did it with the Woods now fully regrown. Adora risks peeking an eye open, finding Catra poking at a trackerpad she has placed on the vanity before the screen goes dim. Adora begins to frown but slams her eye shut quickly as Catra turns back to face her way. For a moment she hears nothing, then the near-silent sound of Catra's breathing draws closer and the mattress dips down.

Catra carefully climbs up the bed and flops down between Adora's back and the wall, curling around behind her back. Adora is a little shocked. She expected this to be another desperate – and a touch aggressive – encounter, but for a long moment, Catra just wraps around her tightly like she needs a hug. Adora is sure that she isn't fooling her into thinking that she is sleeping, but she also doesn't want to shatter the moment. Still, there is the matter of the tablet that Catra bought.

"Is that a tracker?" Adora asks, her voice almost low enough to be a whisper. At her back, Catra snorts.

"It' s a predictive map of the woods. Entrapta made it. When I came before I was testing to see if it was still accurate after the freeze," Catra replies, and then promptly bites the bare flesh of Adora's shoulder, exposed by the thin straps of her sleep top. Adora gasps out, suddenly unconcerned with what Catra brought or how she got here. Catra's tail thumps against the bed with satisfaction. The arm thrown over Adora shifts as Catra sets to running her hands over her.

Adora lets Catra touch her how she likes. It has been weeks and she has been feeling her absence. She felt like she was going crazy at the Tower when it turned out that Catra wasn't even there, and that was before the Northern Reach mission. She needs this. She needs Catra. She is so sick of fighting her. She is so sick of walking on tiptoes trying to avoid anyone even knowing who she is when there is someone out there that knows her so perfectly.

"I expected you to fight more," Catra snarks at her as she bites down on her shoulder and hooks her hand into Adora's waistband. Adora snorts. She isn't sure why. Adora has eagerly let Catra have anything that she wants from her when they were alone. Catra isn't talking about literally fighting, of course, but Adora doesn't feel like trying to give Catra a speech about morality right now. It wouldn't work and she doesn't want to encourage her to leave.

"As long as I get to touch you too, I'm happy," Adora tells her. She is actually in a low spot and isn't sure she remembers what happiness is, but she knows that she has always considered Catra a source of it before. Lately thinking about her has been stressful, leaving her chest aching with conflicting wants that will never be fulfilled while she has this duty to Etheria she must put first. She needs to allow herself this moment with her if she is going to keep getting up and fighting this war.

Catra snorts when she releases Adora's shoulder, apparently amused by Adora's request, but she doesn't protest. Then again, she is bit busy laving her tongue over the spot where Adora vaguely hopes a bruise will be left despite how she would have to explain it.

Adora kicks her legs a little to help Catra as she pushes her shorts and underwear down in one go. She would be just as happy to cuddle as she is to have sex, but Catra probably wouldn't allow that.

It's easier when it's sex. She has a feeling that Catra justifies this to herself as a biological need that she is *making* Adora fulfill for her as if they both don't know that Adora is wrapped around her finger and would do anything that she wants for her – minus join the Horde again, of course. Anything somewhat moral, then. Adora isn't sure where on the scale sleeping with the enemy falls, but at the same time, Catra has never been her enemy. Rival, yes, maybe even nemesis – but not enemy. Catra is her *everything*. Everything positive and sometimes, everything negative.

If Catra wants to pretend that she is coming all the way to the heart of enemy territory for a meaningless lay, Adora isn't going to say anything to indicate that she is onto her and send her running back to the Fright Zone. It would make more sense for Catra to go to Scorpia if feelings really *aren't* involved, but if Adora pointed any of that out, Catra might do it just to prove her point. Adora has already been broken hearted enough over the things that Catra has done. She doesn't need to cause something like that. She can go along with the denial.

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Catra doesn't bolt the second that Adora comes, but she didn't expect her to. After all, she needs her turn too. Adora rolls over and happily curls around Catra, cuddling her close as she works on evening out her breathing. Her own hand really can't compare to Catra's touch. It especially can't compare to getting to touch *her*. Adora uses the few moments of lenience that Catra is willing to give her after getting off to snuggle her close like nothing ever happened. Catra is surprisingly receptive.

She lets Adora snuggle against her shoulder and wrap her arms around her. Adora hums a little as she scatters soft kisses against what little of Catra's neck that she can reach above her collar. Catra doesn't complain about Adora's affection or how slow she is to start running her hands over her with intent. She doesn't even move when Adora sits up to undress her properly. She has been an active participant even when Adora was taking care of her these last few times – as if to assert that she was also in control – but today she lies back and lets Adora do it all.

Maybe in her head she is *making* Adora do it all, but Adora doesn't care either way. It means that she gets to lay next to a naked Catra, running her hands and mouth over her. Catra is almost *cuddly*, curling into Adora and letting her touch her however she wants. She doesn't even complain when Adora takes a minute to bury her face in the soft fluff over her heart. Adora is feeling either emboldened or desperate for her. As she finally wanders a hand down to touch her properly, she tries to kiss her.

Catra doesn't pull away. She kisses Adora back, the embrace turning desperate immediately. Maybe it started that way. Adora has *missed* Catra's lips against her, daydreamed about her tongue, and yearned to taste her again. She kisses Catra hungrily and Catra seems more than willing to bury a hand in Adora's hair and assert all her control over Adora through the kiss. Adora gets to touch Catra however she likes with her hands as Catra takes control over her mouth.

It is a greater high than her earlier orgasm. She loves kissing Catra again. She isn't entirely sure why Catra has been cagey about letting her do it since they ended up on opposite sides. It could easily be passed off as just a part of sex if Catra is really so concerned about pretending that there are no emotions between them – or rather, that she doesn't have emotions herself. Adora knows it is the furthest thing from true. She eagerly whimpers into the kiss, happy to keep kissing Catra until her lips bruise.

They have never had a kiss this desperate, not even when they were in a horde hallway, both worked up and sweating through their

hastily pulled aside clothes, but Adora loves it. It almost feels like she can express all the need and desire for Catra that has been building up for months through it. From the way that Catra kisses her back, she hopes that Catra is thinking the same thing. They might as well be drowning in each other. Adora would never touch Catra as an *afterthought*, but she has a feeling that the kiss is doing more for Catra than her touch is.

Catra arches up beneath her touch, but she isn't pressing into her hand even as she pants short, ragged breathes against Adora's lips, barely pulling back long enough to suck in air before she kisses Adora again. Adora keeps up the contact, doing her best to keep kissing Catra without letting her suffocate herself as she comes. Catra doesn't even pull back, nor do her kisses seem any less desperate, but she slows down a little and pauses to draw in breath at least.

Adora shifts back to holding her as Catra's usual purr rattles through her. Adora kisses not only her mouth, but her face, jaw, and neck as she draws in deep breaths. She isn't ready for this to end and it seems that Catra isn't either because she keeps not only letting Adora do it but meeting her in kind when their lips come together. Eventually, a bit of the desperation slows on Catra's side, her purr beginning to fade. It only makes Adora more needy, kissing her more forcefully and tightly hugging her as if Catra is already trying to wiggle away.

"Will you let me kiss you now?" she asks in between kisses. Catra rolls her eyes, opening her mouth no doubt to say something snarky, but Adora kisses her again. She knows Catra is already letting her kiss her, but they *both* know that Adora isn't talking about tonight. It will be easier to let Catra slip away back to the Fright Zone – though never *easy* – if she knows that she will get to embrace her like this again. She has missed Catra's kisses just as desperately as she has missed every other part of her.

She misses Catra's laugh – her genuine one, warm and delighted – and she misses the joyful sparkle in her eyes as they would goof

around. She misses Catra's lingering touches and the excuses they would find to touch each other. She misses when Catra would lay on whatever Adora needed and pretend it was to annoy her rather than admit that she just wanted Adora's attention and an excuse for Adora's hands to be on her, even if that touch was to shove her out of the way.

Adora isn't getting any of those things back any time soon, so she is eager to reclaim one of the things that she misses from Catra which might be on the table. Kisses might be a slippery slope, even Adora can admit that, but it isn't like they can get any *more* wrapped up in each other. Every time one of them appears on the battlefield, the other stops. The entire world practically narrows down to just the two of them. It is like they are inextricably linked.

Despite the way that it sometimes feels like the world is empty without Catra when Adora is alone in her bed, she knows it isn't true. They have survived on opposite sides of the war for this long and though Adora wishes otherwise, she is sure they will continue to do so for some time. Kisses aren't going to lure one of them down the path of abandoning their morals and joining the other side. Well, Adora's morals and Catra's pride. As bad of an idea as it might seem, Adora can't actually imagine any direct consequences of it. They might as well have this small bit of happiness.

"You're ridiculous. You'd rather kiss than fuck," Catra accuses her. Adora doesn't see how that is a bad thing. She doesn't know that it is necessarily true – she *really* likes when she gets to touch Catra, it just isn't the same when she is worried about lavishing her in too much affection and causing her to pull back – but she doesn't think it is wrong either. She likes kissing Catra, she likes touching her, she likes cuddling her, hell, she even likes *fighting* her. Sometimes it feels like it leaves a hole in her chest, but other times it lights her blood on fire with excitement – in a way not that dissimilar to sex, actually.

"I like kissing you. We can do both," Adora replies before kissing Catra again to prove her point. Catra makes a sound both

exasperated and amused beneath her lips, but she lets Adora press in close and run her tongue along the seam of her lips. When she parts them for Adora, she kisses her back slowly. She is either slowing down to torture her or luxuriating in it herself. If she is trying to do the former, she is out of luck. Adora likes all her kisses regardless of speed.

Catra shifts and Adora's body immediately lights up with *no*. She clutches onto her, not wanting to watch her get dressed and leave. Adora realizes with some horror that Catra was letting herself kiss Adora slow because it was *good* kiss. Adora whines a little, burying her face down in Catra's neck as she wills herself to become heavier and pin Catra down to the bed so she can't go back. She doesn't want to give her up. She knows that she can't go to Catra herself, she has a fucking *job*, but having to watch everything that she wants walk away isn't easy.

"I have a fucking army to run, Adora," Catra informs her, wriggling a little beneath her. She is trying to get away, but she isn't using all her strength. Adora wouldn't be able to keep her down if she were, although that would mostly be because in order for her to do so she would probably have to bruise her. She has hurt Catra just as much as Catra has hurt She-ra over the course of the war, but Catra doesn't hurt *Adora* and Adora isn't about to do something to hurt her while they are in bed.

"Just stay until I fall asleep?" Adora asks despite how pathetic she knows it sounds. Waking up without Catra would be hard, but she really doesn't want to watch her go. Catra remains still beneath her for a long moment. Adora isn't sure if she is actually considering it or just stunned into silence by how weak Adora is being. Catra caught her on a bad night, but right now the bad nights are more frequent than the others. The war feels like it is reaching some kind of breaking point despite neither side gaining any significant ground recently.

"Get off of me," Catra tells her, her tone annoyed, but if she were really mad, she would have shoved Adora away, right? Adora petulantly

clings onto her, making no move to leave. Catra sighs, the sound heavy and a touch aggressive. "Off f. Face the wall," Catra orders her , pushing at Adora's shoulder. The direction she is encouraging her isn't towards the edge of the bed, however . Adora hesitates, but after a moment she lets Catra go and reluctantly rolls off of her until she is facing the wall that the bed is against.

Catra shifts and wraps around her back. For a moment, Adora thinks that she is going to get the only things that she —realistically —wants right now. Then Catra squeezes her just a bit tighter for a few seconds and releases her, turning away and sliding to the edge of the bed. Adora squeezes her eyes shut, forcing her breathing even. Every extra minute that Catra stays is a risky one. Of course she wasn't going to wait for Adora to fall asleep.

Adora doesn't try to stop her . She got a few moments, at least, and she doesn't want to watch as Catra pulls on her clothes and quietly gathers back up her trackerpad. A slight scraping signals her exit from the balcony ledge. Adora still doesn't turn around. There is a warm spot in the bed behind her with a few loose furs clinging to it. If she lies to herself hard enough, she can picture Catra still lying there, staying with her all night and into the morning.

It's pathetic, but it's what Adora needs right now. No one has to know about her internal moment of weakness.

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Adora's bad feeling is justified. Things take a turn. Fucking Shadow Weaver shows up, Adora finds out she isn't a human, and Angella and Castaspella both find out while interrogating their "prisoner" who the hell Adora was before she found the sword. Adora sits in a hard, straight-backed chair in one of the castle's sitting rooms while Angella paces in front of the fire. Glimmer sits just as dejectedly on a

loveseat with Bow beside her, who is shooting Angella pleading looks.

"And to not only bring a Force Captain into the heart of Bright Moon, but to *live* with it?" Angella continues her scolding. She is definitely mad, but she hasn't locked Adora up yet. Adora shrinks down in her seat, trying her best to disappear. Her words are angry hisses and her movements are jerky with her frustration.

"You've seen how much good she has done for the Rebellion! Glimmer was worried you wouldn't give her a chance if we told you," Bow tries to explain. Angella narrows her eyes at him. Bow winces a little, but he doesn't drop the imploring look. "She never saw active duty and she never hurt anybody. As soon as she found out what the Horde was really doing, she left. Adora, tell her," Bow tries, turning to where Adora is trying to will herself out of existence.

All eyes in the room turn on her. Adora supposes she should be grateful this is happening in a private room and not the middle of the throne room like some of Angella's and Glimmer's fights have been in the past, but Adora would guess that Angella doesn't want word of this to get out. It would reflect badly on the Rebellion if people knew that a former Force Captain was secretly amongst their ranks. Adora forces herself to sit up a little since disappearing into thin air doesn't appear to be one of She-ra's abilities.

"People in the Horde aren't all evil. Most of the cadets were just raised there and don't know anything else. We were kept ignorant of a lot," Adora says, quietly. She isn't just talking about herself. Catra might have known more and been desensitized to the horrors of the situation, but Adora knows that she isn't working for the Horde because she is a bad person. She knows Catra's heart better than anyone else and though she guards it with spikes made of iron, it is a loving one. Adora doesn't know if anyone loves with the intensity that Catra does.

"I invited you into my home and you lied to me. All three of you did," Angella responds. That *hits*. Adora feels herself gasp a little and

she quickly screws her eyes up. She refuses to cry. She can't. She earned this.

"Mom, please, we weren't trying to hurt anybody. We were trying to make sure you gave her the chance to help," Glimmer begs. Adora chances opening her eyes to find Angella looking down at Glimmer with an unreadable expression, but at least she doesn't look outright angry anymore.

"It was a foolish, immature, and stupid decision. Just because you judged her correctly doesn't mean I'm going to let it go that you lied to me like this," Angella says to her. Glimmer winces a little, sending Angella the big puppy eyes that she sometimes uses on Adora and Bow. Angella only watches her daughter pout up at her for a moment before she looks back to Adora. Adora stills, not wanting to breathe offensively and fuck this up. Angella's words are a bit harsh, but Adora is pretty sure that they are an indication that she is winding down.

"When you first came here, you claimed the Horde would harm someone if they found out you were helping the Rebellion. Was that ever true?" Angella asks. Adora winces, looking down at her own lap again.

"I came up with it as a cover so people wouldn't find out that I was one of the Horde, but yes. The Horde doesn't care about hurting its own. Those I was close with before would have faced consequences for my defection," Adora admits. For a moment, silence hangs in the air as Adora's throat works but no sound comes out. She swallows, drawing in air and forcing the words out, finally, after years of keeping them buried.

"Catra would have. Shadow Weaver knew what she was to me," Adora says. There aren't words for what Catra was to her, much less what she is to her now, but the phrase implies all that it needs to. Adora knows it probably isn't a shocking revelation given how they act around each other, at least not for Glimmer and Bow, but the room seems to ring with a shocked silence.

"I've been fighting my- my best friend for you this entire time. Doesn't that count for something?" Adora asks, finally looking up to make eye contact with Angella. Angella's mouth is pressed in a thin line, but Adora watches her eyes soften.

"Yes. It does," Angella agrees. Adora blows out a breath. They are in trouble and they are going to continue to be for a while probably, but Adora is pretty sure that Angella is going to forgive them and that is a weight off her shoulders. Discovery has felt inevitable this entire time – probably because they *have* been discovered, multiple times in fact – but now Angella knows, it kind of doesn't matter. Adora is sure this will remain a "secret", but if the leaders of the Rebellion are backing her, everything won't fall apart should her identity become public knowledge.

It also means a lot less sneaking around. Adora goes from struggling to breathe to feeling lighter than she has in weeks.

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Adora thought everything was going to hell before. It gets worse. It hits *rock bottom*. Nothing can get worse than the portal. Nothing very nearly *has* Adora like the portal. She manages to get through it, but only barely. Others aren't so lucky. Adora tries not to think about it. Catra didn't intend for Angella to get locked inside, but the schism that has opened between them turns into a gaping gorge that day. Catra visited her a few times, but she doesn't do it again after that.

They don't even see each other in battle all that often anymore. Catra has retreated to the Fright Zone and Adora is left broken and wondering. *How* did they end up here? Did she love Catra wrong? She is more desperate for her than she has ever been, but at the same time, she doesn't think she could pretend the war doesn't exist

and let Catra in her bed again. She needs it more than she ever did before, but she can't just ignore everything that has happened.

She has to believe that Catra isn't beyond hope, but she can't fall into her arms again until she gets *something* from her. For months, she doesn't even get a look. Adora struggles to find any light. Angella is gone, she and Glimmer can't stop fighting, Catra is out of reach, Shadow Weaver is slinking around Bright Moon Castle and only kept quiet about Adora's identity by the oath that Glimmer made her swear before releasing her, and on top of it all, the war is taking a turn for the worse. Adora gets out of bed not because she is motivated, but because of obligation. She has to see this through. She either has to end this war or let it end her.

She has already lost everything to it. She will be nothing if she doesn't at least give her life to the cause. Still, Catra haunts her dreams. Adora wakes up feeling empty. She makes questionable decisions, trying to make a difference or trying to get Catra's attention. She recognizes Catra in her own actions. Was this what she felt like at the start of the war, when she would call taunts and revel in Adora's burning glare? The longer it stretches, the more it feels like any attention from her, good or bad, would be enough to light her blood on fire again.

She is a mess, but she will be the She-ra that the war needs. She will fight the Horde until the last. There is nothing else for her to do. She has to make Angella's sacrifice worth it. She has to fulfill her destiny. She has to show Glimmer that she can make a difference. Maybe Glimmer will always wish that Adora was the one who got left behind instead of her mom, but Glimmer isn't the only one. All Adora can do is try to live up to Angella's memory. If Angella sacrificed herself only for Adora to lose them the war, she would never be able to live with herself. She will do what she has to.

Then the sword breaks.

Chapter End Notes

I know Catra broke the trackerpad she had the initial Whispering Woods map on, but I assume Entrapta has multiple copies, and if not, she can remake it. It wasnt all that accurate, but it' s enough when you have the motivation of a booty call LOL. Nothing horny for the Crimson Waste, sorry. I thought about it and Adora would have opened her fat mouth about Shadow Weaver before they did anything, and then it was completely off the table after that. The mission went a bit dif ferently than it did in the show, but it ended the same, and I didnt want to derail to retell a mission from the show when the parts with Catra and Adora were largely the same.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> References some parts of Don't Go by annacharlier (the fic written by Noelle). This AU is semi/mostly-canon to it.
> Same CWs as last chapter, but little milder I think.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She-ra's identity became an open-air secret in the Rebellion at some point. Adora is pretty sure that she walked into a Princess Alliance meeting during those last few months without the sword once and nobody even noticed – she says *pfft* because she didn't even have the realization until she was in bed that night and it seemed too surreal to be true since the meeting went as usual and nobody said anything.

There is no keeping her identity a secret now. She-ra is gone and everyone is too busy fighting for their lives to care about who used to fight for who theoretically. Adora kind of forgets that it was a secret herself because she is accepted as herself so quickly.
Unsurprisingly, it is Scorpia that accidentally reveals her past. Adora wasn't really paying attention when Scorpia sat down next to her during an informal meeting that gathered in the middle of dinner just because a report came in then. It bites her in the end.

When they are done going over losses and strategy, Adora's brain feels fried. She even finds herself slumping against Scorpia's side for support. She is constantly running on empty and she blames that for why she does it, but she also doesn't… *don't like* Scorpia like she used to. She was always just jealous of how close Scorpia was to Catra. Scorpia was easily available, seemingly eager, and on the same side of the war as her.

No one knows where Catra is now, though. A lot of the Horde was scattered after the Heart activated and Prime arrived. Some of them

slipped away into society, blending into the crowd. Some of them stayed in small factions that are at least also fighting Prime and leaving the Rebellion alone for now. Some of them even joined the Rebellion. If Catra is in any of those groups, she is pretending to be somebody else far more successfully than Adora ever did.

Adora has gradually found that she and Scorpia have a bit of a connection. A weird one, built on mutual admiration for a missing person that they both worry about at night, but it is nice to have someone to talk to, not just about Catra, but about life after the Horde. They always have those talks in private, but maybe Scorpia just thought they were trying not to rub talking about Catra positively in front of all the other people who spent so long fighting her, because Scorpia bites into what little of her dinner she didnt finish over the course of the meeting and looks down at Adora, asking *j eedyouknowwhereshegotthat?Oh ni ng otreeasse* like the words are nothing. Adora, barely awake, doesnt even react.

"There was a grow room somewhere in the Fright Zone where they raised the plants that went into the bars. Catra and I found it once when we were looking for somewhere to make out. They also extracted minerals from the ground to add for our dietary requirements. Dunno about the rest," Adora yawns, screwing up her eyes with the motion. Her hand isnt big enough to fully cover her mouth. She feels like she might have unhinged her jaw by the time that the yawn ends, but it clicks back shut still. It doesnt matter how tired she is, she cant go to bed. A messenger with another update is supposed to come in an hour.

"Wait, was there actually dirt in them? I always *thought* they tasted a bit like dirt, but everybody told me I was crazy!" Scorpia replies. Adora hums noncommittally. She has no idea, she just saw a file on Shadow Weaver's desk once about the balance of nutrients that were supposed to be in the bars and a list of some of the sources. Adora knows that she should open her eyes and that keeping them

closed after yawning is a slippery slope that could lead to her falling asleep in the middle of camp, but she really doesnt want to move.

"Excuse me, are we going to skip over the part about you and Catra?" Castaspella asks. "That is the motivation – if you can call it that – that Adora needs to open her eyes. She finds half the loose semicircle of people glancing at her curiously and the other half looking at Castaspella. Adora suddenly becomes grateful that this meeting was so impromptu and thus Shadow Weaver hasnt seemed to have found out about it and weaseled her way over. Adora doesnt know she would have recovered from saying that in front of her.

"Please, as if that was a secret. Im pretty sure they did the same thing at Princess Prom," Mermista scof fs, easily dismissing the question before it can become a true moment of tension. Adora feels her face heat. Yeah, that's definitely all they did. She would protest Mermista's words – not because they're wrong, but because she doesnt think they were that transparent at the party – but she is aware that at *t mes* she and Catra have been a bit obvious.

"The fact she was ever with the Horde should be bigger news, but Castaspella already knew that from when Shadow Weaver spilled it. Adora didnt realize that Castaspella didnt know about Catra. From the faces around the campfire, however, no one seems all that surprised by either of the revelations. Adora doesnt know how she feels about that. The secret hasnt weighed on her heavily since Angella discovered it, but she spent a long time pretending that she was nothing, just a regular civilian unrelated to She-ra.

Since losing her, she has been desperate to prove that *Adora* is worth something on her own even if she cant be She-ra. She cant do the things that she used to, but she is determined to do all that she can until they are able to rescue Glimmer . Once that is done, Adora will turn her attention to tracking down what happened to Catra. "Then..." She doesnt have a plan for after that. She doesnt think she is going to need one. Her noble goals are rescuing her friends and fighting Prime. Once that is done – *i f* that is done – she is sure the next hurdle will present itself to her.

Her entire life has been fighting. She will go down doing it if she has to. As long as her friends are safe, she doesnt care. She expected them to care a bit more about who is fighting for them, but no one says anything after Castaspella. Well, not anything about Adora or Catra. Mermista returns to deriding Sea Hawk for whatever faux pas he committed before Scorpia asked Adora her initial question – Adora may have zoned out and missed that anything was happening until Mermista punched Sea Hawk's shoulder – and soon there is a small murmur around the campfire again.

Years of secrecy and it turns out that all it takes is the world ending for nobody to care where Adora was raised. She wonders what Catra would say about it if she knew. She always mocked this plan from the beginning. She would probably laugh her face blue if she found out that all the subterfuge was for nothing. If she is somewhere- *Wherever* she is, Adora will have to tell her once she finds her again. The world very nearly ending puts a lot of things in perspective. Adora would kill to see Catra's smile again.

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Adora spent years living as two different people. She-ra and Adora were separate and unrelated. One was a leader in the Rebellion and another was a mere civilian who had seen enough of the war when it drove her from her home. Neither were actually Adora, just two facets of who she was or could be.

It turns out that they arent as separate as even Adora thought they were. As they fly to Prime's ship, refueled and heading into what could very well be a trap, Adora lies in her small bunk and tries to feel the power that she felt as the cave collapsed. She hasnt felt She-ra in so long. The thought that she is still in there somewhere is exhilarating. Just lying there as Bow snores, she isnt able to

summon her, but she doesn't think that she fully managed that in the cave either.

She found a sliver of her power again, at least. She is probably going to need it if they are going to rescue Catra. Adora worried that she was in a lot of places over the weeks of silence after Prime landed, but somehow this possibility never occurred to her. Maybe it is for the best that it didn't – she didn't need *more* to worry about – but now Adora finds Catra's words from over the comm replaying in her ears as she tries to sleep.

I'm sorry. Adora wonders if Catra was closer than she thought to breaking and staying for the night whenever she snuck over. Those words weren't something that she ever expected to hear from Catra. She has an unshakable hope beating in her chest now. She will stop at nothing until she gets to see her again. For months she has needed *something* from Catra, and it turns out those words were it. Adora is coming for her whether she wants her to or not.

Adora isn't leaving another friend behind and Catra was always far more than just that to her. Adora will find her no matter where she is or what it takes.

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The way that Catra clings to her after she heals her reminds Adora of how she clung to Catra when she tried to leave on their last real night together. Adora looks in Catra's eyes and she doesn't see the woman that she battled for the last few years. She sees the scared little kitten that she grew up with in the Horde, underfed and always seeming to get more punishments than the others did. Somewhere along the line, Catra broke just as surely as Adora did.

Adora doesnt want to ever lose her again, but Catra keeps pushing her away just like she did before. Adora let Catra in only for her to hurt her and leave her hollow too many times. Adora risked her life to get Catra back, but she always would have done that. It is a given. She wants Catra to at least be grateful to the others that risked their necks just because of who Catra is to her . Offering the ultimatum when Catra freaks out about the chip removal hurts Adora, but she doesnt know what else to do. Catra has made her feel whole and broken in equal measure at different times, and sometimes —like *now* —at the same time.

When Catra calls to her, reaches *out* to her, Adora's heart beats wildly in her chest. She looks down at Catra, kneeling and looking up to her as she asks her to *stay* , and she feels choked by her own emotions.

She is in love with Catra. She has tried to avoid thinking it for a long time, but looking down at her now, Adora cant think of anything but that she loves her and she just might be getting her *back* . The small kitten that Adora befriended and first fell in love with is gone and there is no getting her back, but the Adora with a gap between her front teeth is gone too. They still know each other inextricably and, if Catra is willing to try, they can be everything that they were before again, this time with years of experience stretching behind them.

They were years of pain too, but Adora doesnt care if she gets the love of her life back.

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Catra leaves in the middle of dinner, but she doesnt storm out in anger. In fact, she leaves quietly . She is clearly upset, but she doesnt lash out like Adora is used to her doing. Adora stays until dinner is done, unsure if seeking Catra out will trigger the fight that

she held back from starting, but when she finds Catra curled up in a hallway, fast asleep with tear tracks on her face, she doesn't hesitate to scoop her up. She does it as carefully as she can, trying to avoid waking her, but her efforts turn out to be for nothing. Catra wakes when Adora sets her down on her bed.

They have shared a bed a few times since the war began, but Adora is still surprised when Catra asks her to stay. Every time there was a pretense to it and Catra left as soon as they were done. There is none of that now. Catra isn't awake enough for anything more than being held, but she still invites Adora into the bed. Adora almost doesn't dare to touch her, afraid to shatter the spell – they haven't addressed *them* once, a little busy running for their lives and trying to get Catra back on her feet – but when Adora doesn't cross the gap, Catra invites her to with a carefully-placed sweep of her tail.

Adora speaks Catra. The tail on her leg is as good an invitation as a handwritten letter. Adora happily scoots closer and Catra lets Adora hold her in her arms. Catra thanks her. She promises to be *better*. Adora feels like she is the one questioning if this is real now. Catra curling up in her arms and falling asleep purring, both of them on the same side for once, is all that she has wanted for years. The future is still uncertain, but Adora is lulled to sleep by Catra's gentle purring.

When she wakes, Catra is still there and it isn't a dream. Adora buries her face in Catra's hair and runs her hands over the fur exposed by her lack of proper clothes, soaking in her softness. Catra doesn't stir where she has her face smashed into Adora's chest, her head tucked underneath her chin. Adora isn't sure how she is even breathing with how tightly she is pressed into her, but she isn't complaining. She just woke up with Catra in her arms. There isn't a lot to be mad about. She pets over her carefully, not wanting to wake her or press any bruises that may still be healing.

She just wants to feel Catra beneath her hands and know that she is real. She has spent so long wishing that Catra would come back to her. Eventually, it reached the point where what little that they still had together seemed past the point of salvation. Adora is so grateful

that she has this now. She needs to appreciate it and ground herself with Catra's touch. The war is still hanging over their heads, but she can forget about it while she has Catra in her arms.

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Adora hopefully follows Catra after dinner the next night. Catra glances over her shoulder and raises her eyebrow at Adora as she trails a few feet behind her. Adora sends her a sheepish but hopeful smile. The corner of Catra' s mouth quirks up and she looks forward again, continuing on the path back to her room. Adora counts it as a win that Catra doesnt tell her to fuck of f. They have been cautiously feeling each other out since reuniting, but the ship is small for five people and they havent gotten a lot of time alone.

Catra doesnt invite Adora into her room when she reaches it, but she doesnt close the door immediately behind her . Adora happily slips in before it automatically slides shut. Catra sends her an amused look as she sits on the edge of her bed and slowly stretches out her limbs, her extremities trembling just a little. Adora approaches her, standing in front of her and waiting until Catra's body has relaxed again, her arms dropping limp by her sides.

Adora falls with them, dropping to her knees. Catra blinks down at her in surprise as Adora rests her head in her lap, raising her arms and loosely looping them behind Catra so she can hug her torso. Adora lets her eyes slip closed, humming a little to herself as she happily relaxes against Catra. Unfortunately, Entrapta finished making Catra an outfit and it has pants, so Adora isnt putting her face in the soft fur on Catra's thighs right now, but she is happy enough just to hold her .

After a moment in which Catra seems to hesitate, Adora feels a hand on her head, stroking cautiously before her ponytail is being tugged

on. It pulls her hair a little, but Adora doesn't move as Catra pulls out her ponytail and sets to carding her fingers through her hair. Adora wasn't feeling bold enough to just climb in Catra's bed without an invitation, but she sighs happily now, glad to be allowed to cuddle her like this at least. Catra might send her away yet, but Adora hopes not. She has spent too long sleeping alone.

"Are you going to stay on the floor?" Catra asks. Her tone is amused, but there is an edge to it. Adora opens her eyes, looking up to find Catra looking down at her. Despite her raised brow, there is an edge of nervousness in her gaze. Adora hesitates. She will gladly climb into bed if Catra wants her to, but everything feels strangely tenuous between them. Why was this easier when they were fighting?

Actually, she knows the answer. There were mind games going on. Their touches were often genuine, but if something was too much – too soft, too hard, too loving – they could pretend that it was all part of some strategy for the war. Anything they do now is real. If Catra rejects her, it is a real rejection. If Catra opens up to her, it is because she wants to. Adora swallows, nodding against Catra's thigh and lifting her head. Catra swings her legs up onto the bed, pointedly laying on only one side of it.

Adora toes out of her boots and sheds her jacket, circling around the bed to climb into it from the other side. They lay down in a mirror of the positions they took last night, only this time Adora lifts her arm hopefully and Catra immediately shuffles forward. Simulated night should fall on the ship any minute now and Adora takes the last few minutes of light to let her eyes roam over Catra's face, so close that her breath is puffing on Adora's face.

Catra is doing the same, her eyes flicking over every inch of Adora's face as if cataloguing her freckles and blackheads. Adora gained a few small scars since they last saw each other as a consequence of fighting without She-ra at her disposal, but aside from that not much has changed about Adora. A lot has changed about Catra. Some of it is physical – the hair is a big one, as is the healing scar on the

back of her neck, even if Adora can't see it right now – but a lot of it is just in the way that Catra carries herself now.

Her eyes are wide, her expression raw as she looks at Adora. She is making no attempt to mask her emotions. The last time that she was open like this they were hooking up in an abandoned storage closet and Adora could hardly make out her expression in the dim light spilling in from the hallway under the crack of the door. Even before the war, Catra wore a mask to keep herself safe in the Horde. She only took it off for Adora occasionally. Adora has still seen her mask come up several times throughout the day, the old defensive habit hard to break, but she feels a bit breathless looking at Catra and really getting to *see* her.

When the lights blink out, neither of them gives any signal, but they still lean in together as one and kiss. It is the first time since before the portal. It is somehow more desperate than the last one that they shared but also more content. The desperation comes from a long gap and overwhelming emotions, but for once, none of them are fear. Every one of their kisses that night felt like it could be the last one, possibly forever. Tonight, Adora isn't afraid of that. She just wants to kiss Catra.

Catra kisses her back, letting out the softest whimper as she presses closer. Adora wraps an arm tightly around her and squeezes her close, flexing her arm and silently sending the signal that *I'm here, I'm not going anywhere*. Catra's tail thumps against the bed and then her legs tangle with Adora's own, the tight hug and kiss apparently not enough. They press together from their ankles to their lips. It is hard to draw in air, but it feels like breathing for the first time in a long time when their lips are together.

When they are eventually forced to part for breath, Catra is far from done, pressing their cheeks together and rubbing her scent on Adora with so much force that she scoots her back on the mattress a little. Adora happily holds her as she does so, clinging onto her not because she is afraid of her leaving but because she wants to make up for lost time. She might not really know where they stand in this

new uncharted territory of honesty, but she knows that she doesn't want to let Catra go.

She tried that once, after the portal. It only made her miserable. Catra is changing and Adora doesn't know where that will leave them, but it is beautiful to watch. If giving up these stolen moments means that she gets to see Catra's face open and honest every day, a changed woman ready to give the world a chance, then she will do it in an instant, but until Catra tells her to stop, she is going to keep taking in every moment that she can.

For the second day in a row, Adora falls asleep with Catra purring in her arms.

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"Whatever happened with your dumbass secret identity plan?" Catra asks, yawning widely. Adora is in a stare-off with Melog, who is in her spot cuddled against Catra's chest. Both Melog and Catra seem smug about it. Adora doesn't want to be rude and kick them out on their first night on the ship, but she has been sleeping in Catra's bed ever since the first night that Catra asked her to stay. They haven't really been talking about it, though Glimmer and Bow have been shooting Adora knowing looks.

Sometimes they kiss, and sometimes one of them wanders their hands, but they haven't touched each other really. It feels more like they are both trying to confirm that the other is really there. In the middle of lunch yesterday, Catra reached out and poked Adora harshly with her claw. Adora asked her what that was for and Catra seemed unable to come up with an answer before she eventually muttered, "Just making sure."

She hasn't had any true fits of delirium since they removed the chip, but it wasn't hard to figure out that she was making sure Adora would react like, well, a person who was just almost stabbed by her best friend and not whatever the simulations that Prime tortured Catra with did. When Adora runs her hands over Catra, it is often for similar reasons, needing to make sure she didn't dream this up. Adora pets Catra's soft fur and assures herself that she is okay. Catra squeezes Adora in turn as if she might disappear beneath her fingers.

"We got caught so many times," Adora admits, still staring at Melog. Catra snorts and Melog echoes the sound in a reverberating chuff. It's cute, but they are also stealing her cuddles. Catra seems to be preening, far too satisfied with Adora's jealousy. It isn't the ugly jealousy that she once felt for Scorpia, but Adora really wants to hold Catra. She definitely doesn't want to go back to sleeping alone in her bunk down in the hold where the others have set up. She doesn't even care about Bow's snoring, she just wants to be with Catra.

"I *told* you," Catra responds, obviously smug. Adora would point out once again that it wasn't actually her plan, but she stops caring about the semantics when Catra shuffles forward. Adora feels no shame about the way she perks up as Melog reluctantly scoots back to the edge of the bed so Catra can make her way to the middle. Adora doesn't hesitate to climb into the empty side. Is she very nearly falling out? Absolutely, there isn't enough room for all three of them here. Is Catra still facing and cuddling Melog rather than her? Also yes, although trying to roll over now would be likely dislodge one of them.

Adora doesn't care. She wraps tightly around Catra's back, using both her arms and legs to press their bodies together as tightly as they can go. She sighs happily as she tucks her face into Catra's short hair for a moment. She knows that Catra didn't choose it, but it is nice for cuddling at least. Her mane could get in the way, even if Adora liked it too. She likes pretty much any version of Catra. There are versions that she loves more – namely, the ones that let Adora in

—but Adora is always going to love Catra no matter what form she takes.

"Tell me about it," Catra requests, her chest vibrating ever so slightly. Adora releases a *hmph* of acknowledgement that makes Catra laugh. Adora will tell her, but only after she is done snuggling Catra and rubbing her face into her softness. It's kind of hard to tell a story with hair in your mouth. Adora isn't inclined to ever pull back, but eventually oxygen deprivation gets to her and she is forced to pull back so she can suck in a few unhindered breaths.

Catra chuckles, the sound soft and warm. Catra "chuckled" a lot during the war, but the sound was always harsh with a twist of gloating and cruelty to it. It wasn't her real laugh—this huffy, slightly scratchy sound is. It feels *right* in Adora's ears and reverberating through her ribs. Unable to help herself, Adora ducks her head down and presses a soft kiss to the raw spot on the back of Catra's neck, careful not to hurt her still-healing wound. Catra immediately gasps, the chuckle dying in an instant, though her chest continues to buzz with a telling purr.

Adora pauses, worried that she has hurt her despite how Catra's other signals seem to indicate pleasure. Catra lets out a small sound in the back of her throat, too short to really be considered a whine, but it is needy nonetheless. Cautiously, Adora kisses the spot again, lingering this time. Catra's purr buzzes through Adora's arm wrapped her. Adora shifts her hand, placing it over Catra's chest and splaying the fingers out so she can feel her heartbeat. It is racing.

"That's- that can't be hygienic," Catra stammers out, but her voice is breathless. Adora smiles to herself, burying her face in Catra's hair again as she squeezes her tight. On the other side of Catra, Melog releases a small, somewhat confused sound. Adora lifts her head enough to look at them over Catra and finds them with their head tilted, glancing between Catra and Adora. They don't seem to understand what is going on.

"Maybe. But you like it," Adora replies, ducking her head and placing one last lingering kiss on the spot. She kind of wants to make out now, but they have a guest, so instead she drops her head back down on the pillow and settles for holding Catra close. Besides, Catra asked Adora to tell her a story and it's kind of hard to talk while kissing. Adora would gladly take the challenge, but it won't be tonight.

"Entrapta was the first person to find out," Adora admits. Catra releases a small, surprised sound. It's cute. Adora smiles to herself as she hugs Catra tightly. Entrapta never told then. She really tries so hard. She has done some misguided things, but so has Catra. Adora isn't going to hold it over them, not if they're doing better now.

"Princess prom also outed me a bit, apparently. Mermista and Sea Hawk just assumed I was She-ra from that point forward. Sea Hawk didn't even think that it was a secret," Adora adds on. Catra snorts, her tail flicking against Adora's legs with amusement. Adora didn't find out that was the case until they were trying to explain to Sea Hawk that Adora's identity was in fact a secret, but not knowing that she was caught at the time doesn't make her identity any less known.

"Oh, I skipped one. Glimmer's aunt was onto us after we visited her and She-ra only appeared when I wasn't around," Adora adds. Catra snorts again, her ear flicking back towards Adora.

"Who *didn't* discover you?" she asks. Adora pauses. *A lot of people*, she wants to say, but by the time that she lost She-ra, no one seemed surprised by the reveal. It isn't like they had a meeting where Adora admitted that she was She-ra or anything, it was more like Adora told the Princess Alliance that the sword was broken and she couldn't use She-ra anymore and everybody rushed to assure her. Not a single person expressed surprise at her statement.

"Probably no one," Adora admits. Catra, rightfully, laughs at her.

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Adora has been through hell and back, but nothing breaks her heart like watching Catra walk away after she thought that they would get the rest of the war – maybe even the rest of their lives – together. They haven't gotten much time alone together since returning to Etheria especially with Shadow Weaver hanging around and killing any desire to be too obviously close, but Adora thought that they were making progress. Years of wanting and yearning, days of having and hoping, and everything collapses in a night.

Adora knows that she is walking towards her death. She always has been. She was hoping that Catra would hold her hand for the last leg, but she isn't expecting Catra to return now. How many times can they break before there is no putting their pieces back together? Adora marches on. She always has. She doesn't know how to stop. Even if Catra hates her, even Catra doesn't want her love, Adora will do anything that she can to make the world one that Catra can live in. Her life is worth that, for Catra and every one of her friends. If Glimmer and Bow get to be happy together, then this will be worth it too.

Even without Catra, Adora could find some peace in the knowledge that Prime is gone and she has finally fulfilled her duty, but she is grateful when Catra does reappear. She walked away, but it is comforting to have her there again. If only Adora had the strength to finish what she started. The vision she has of them is everything that she has quietly wanted for years and everything that she will never have. It is beautiful. It *hurts*. When Catra appears before her, when Catra says she loves her, something fundamental shifts within Adora.

She has always loved Catra. She always hoped that Catra loved her back. She didn't think it was *like* though. She thought that Catra would have followed her at Thaymor if that was the case. They had something, a connection that couldn't be replicated, but they weren't

what Adora wanted. She tried to shove her emotions down despite how she couldnt stop acting on them. She even tried to move on for a brief period after the portal, but there was no shaking the way that she felt about Catra.

And then Catra says she loves her. Adora says it *back*. They have kissed many times, but none of them have ever tasted as sweet as this one, even with the end of the world quite literally hanging over their heads. This time Adora knows that she wasnt imagining every soft look or justifying why Catra had to be seeking her out for emotional reasons and not just as part of some sick mind game. This time, Adora is determined to never let Catra go.

Their next kiss is on the grass outside, Glimmer and Bow laughing beside them and celebrations surrounding them. Their next kiss is truly the first of many. Their next kiss, Adora wraps Catra in her arms and Catra holds her just as tightly as they kiss slowly and *sweetly* for maybe the first time ever. Their kisses back in the Horde were sometimes soft, but they never felt like this. Then again, Adora didnt know if Catra loved her then.

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She-ra's identity may not have been much of a secret by the end of the war, but that was mostly true amongst the Rebellion itself. Your average citizen was not likely to know who Adora was, or even that there *was* someone beneath She-ra's tiara. They certainly didnt know that Adora was a former member of the Horde. Adora stares at the statement that Catra and Glimmer have put together with an odd sense of cognitive dissonance. She hid for so long, it feels weird to admit this now.

"Is it alright?" Catra prompts, resting her chin on Adora's shoulder. They spend a lot of time holding each other now and Adora is in

Catra's lap at the moment. In her defense, Melog has made themself small and is curled up in her usual seat right now. Adora has no qualms about Melog getting woken up when she wants to move them to hold Catra, or better yet, get alone time with her, but she isn't going to cop to the reason for her sudden respectfulness no matter who asks her about it. She doesn't need to. Everybody knows that she just wants to be touching Catra.

"Yeah. Just weird to be saying it. But it's the right thing to do," Adora assures, turning her head and kissing Catra's temple. It is a simple statement clarifying two things: that Catra has become the royal advisor to the queen of Bright Moon as they work on rebuilding after the war, and that She-ra is a form that Adora, a former member of the Horde herself, summons to defend Etheria with. Glimmer slipped in mention of some of both her and Catra's good deeds, as well as Adora's ability to heal, so the statement informs the public of a lot.

Adora expects that they will see some pilgrims coming to Bright Moon for She-ra's help, but she is happy to give it. Adora is "coming out" now, so to speak, to show the public that reintegration of former members of the Horde isn't just possible, but that it can be for the benefit of all. Yes, Catra helped lead the Horde for some time, but if She-ra fought for the Rebellion and was once a member of it too, can former affiliation with them really be an instant black mark? Catra has already worked to do good for the Rebellion since defecting, both before defeating Prime and after.

There hasn't been a big outcry against former Horde members, at least not that they are aware of, but the point of the statement is to promote unity. Everybody is ready for the fighting to be over. Old grudges run deep and anything that they can do to smooth over the process of rebuilding helps. It just so happens that they have a longtime member of the Rebellion to tout as an example of reform. Adora sets the statement down, now more concerned with kissing the slight hollow right beneath Catra's ear where the fur is decadently soft than with anything on the paper.

“Hey, lovebirds, can I put this out or not?” Glimmer asks from across the table, her tone exasperated. Adora doesn't pull back, shifting to kiss the side of Catra’s face now as Catra purrs softly. Adora gives Glimmer a vague hum of acknowledgement. She is met with a resounding sigh, but a moment later Glimmer reaches across the table, taking the statement from Adora. She took that as the confirmation that it was, then. Good. That means Adora doesn't have to stop scattering kisses across Catra’s face as Catra hugs her tightly around the waist.

They are making up for lost time. They fought each other for years. Everybody else is just going to have to put up with their affection now. It is long overdue.

Chapter End Notes

> I banged this entire AU out in three days but I had other stories to post before it so y’all are only getting it now. I really enjoyed doing something shorter for a bit and might look at doing more short fics or one shots for a little.

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